promising to end China's unfair trading practices and warning that he would challenge Beijing in the South China Sea. After his first few months in office, when it appeared that he would revert to a more traditional posture toward China, Trump levied major tariffs against Chinese goods, ultimately encompassing $550 billion, or nearly all of China's exports to the United States. At the same time, he increased military spending and authorized more FONOPS and aerial overflights in the South China Sea, ultimately increasing them to approximately one every three weeks by the beginning of 2025. Trump's approach was codified in the December 2017 National Security Strategy, which labeled China a "revisionist power" seeking to "displace the United States in the Indo-Pacific region . . . and reorder the region in its favor."[12] Openly acknowledging the strategic competition with China, the Trump administration targeted Chinese technology companies, mused about restricting the numbers of Chinese students in American universities, and sought a decoupling of the two countries' intertwined economies.

Through these years, tensions between Washington and Beijing rose dramatically, and multiple unsafe encounters occurred between the forces of the two nations, always instigated by PLAN ships or Air Force planes. Xi Jinping, who was chairman of the Central Military Commission in addition to being general secretary of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) and president, had told his military as far back as 2018 to "prepare for war," and his exhortations against American interference in China's "rightful" sphere of interest increased over the succeeding years, leading to risk-taking actions on the part of Chinese sailors and pilots.[13] While high-level bilateral diplomatic meetings continued to take place, they resulted in no solutions to the festering problems, and both sides recognized that such gatherings were increasingly for show. Beijing attempted to use Chinese students studying in US universities to whip up pro-Chinese sentiment on campuses and in major US cities, but the efforts backfired after a few student ringleaders revealed the Chinese government's organizing role. While the vast majority of Chinese Americans supported Washington, some activists,